

REVIEW

Römer, U., Cortes, V., & Friginal, E. (2020). *Advances in corpus-based research on academic writing : Effects of discipline, register, and writer expertise* / edited by Ute Römer, Viviana Cortes, Eric Friginal. (Studies in corpus linguistics; v. 95).

Advances in corpus-based research on academic writing: Effects of discipline, register, and writer expertise highlights 15 recent studies from both well-established names and relative newcomers in the field of corpus linguistics, all of whom were invited to contribute to the volume after presenting at a conference of the American Association for Corpus Linguistics (AACL). Edited by Ute Römer, Viviana Cortes, and Eric Friginal of Georgia State University, the book presents work from a variety of researchers working in diverse contexts, providing an overview of some innovative ways corpus methods are being used to examine academic writing. The range of perspectives represented by these studies include several variables that have been found to influence features of academic writing, including the writers' nativeness status or level of expertise, variation across disciplinary and sub-disciplinary categories, and differences in register or text type (e.g. conference abstracts, literature reviews, textbooks) within the broader register of academic writing.

This volume is part of the *Studies in Corpus Linguistics* series, which "focuses on the use of corpora throughout language study, the development of a quantitative approach to linguistics, the design and use of new tools for processing language texts, and the theoretical implications of a data-rich discipline"(John Benjamins). The book contributes to the goals of the series both by showcasing new developments in quantitative and mixed-methods linguistic research, and by illustrating the value of corpus methodology across many areas of language study under the umbrella of academic writing.

While academic writing has been examined extensively and from a variety of perspectives using corpus linguistics methodology (see Gray, 2015), the editors point out that the field still contains extensive possibilities for further research. To support this assertion, this volume is offered to illuminate recent studies pursuing some of these unexplored avenues, providing further understanding of the characteristics of academic writing in a variety of contexts. With its goal of inspiring future research, the collection is best suited to practicing researchers in the field or graduate students working to find a place in the research community. Although understanding the variety of topics and methodological approaches included may require some outside reading for less experienced members of the research community, that same diversity offers a stimulating look at the multitude of possibilities in the field of corpus linguistics.

Part One of the book presents five studies on the influence of writers' expertise and native or non-native speaker status on academic writing. The authors build on previous investigations of these variables by using specialized corpora to explore and describe several aspects of student writing, including vocabulary, key function words, and use of source material. In the first

chapter, Csomay addresses academic word use by English as a Foreign Language (EFL) students in a STEM program in Tbilisi, Georgia. Findings showed similarities in use of academic vocabulary across disciplines, but variation based on level of expertise. Following this is another chapter on second language (L2) learner writing. In this study, Nam investigates the way Korean EFL students use *give* constructions, which have previously been identified as an area of difficulty for this group. Comparing L2 writing with examples of upper-level student writing from an American university, the author offers findings with useful pedagogical implications. Yilmaz and Römer present another study using an English as a Lingua Franca (ELF) corpus. Their key function word and phraseological analysis reveal patterns to better describe ELF academic writing. The next chapter focuses on the influence of writer expertise with a study by Doolan on the use of sources by first-year L1 writers. Using an approach based in multi-dimensional analysis, the author identifies ways in which these novice writers make use of source-based language in their writing. Part One's final chapter by Mbodj and Crossley explores the influence of level of experience on the use of lexical bundles by comparing student writing in medical and non-medical disciplines.

Connecting with the previous chapter's look at discipline as a variable, Part Two of the volume presents four studies that examine disciplinary and sub-disciplinary variation in academic writing. The first of these is a study by Gray, Cotos, and Smith, which utilizes an innovative methodology combining multi-dimensional analysis with rhetorical move analysis to identify connections between linguistic patterns and communicative functions in research articles across 30 disciplines. Next, Reppen and Olson compare the use of lexical bundles across disciplines, both continuous and discontinuous. Their study offers a valuable contribution to the field by examining some less-studied disciplines such as Culinary Science and Interior Design, and the results demonstrate the possible pedagogical value of cross disciplinary bundles. A chapter by Lake and Cortes also explores variation of use in lexical bundles, but with a comparison across English and Spanish psychology, history, and literary criticism texts. Results show significant quantitative and semantic variation across both discipline and language. Dutra et al. also compare disciplines with a study on adjectives premodifying nouns in chemistry and applied linguistics research articles. Their work contributes to the description of both registers by identifying variation in noun phrase length and types of adjectives used. The last chapter on disciplinary variation is a study by Becker and Feng comparing the expression of stance through the use of modal verbs in three types of engineering student writing. The authors provide useful pedagogical implications for science writing by furthering our knowledge of hedging, prediction, and other key rhetorical elements of academic writing.

Register variation has long been a cornerstone of corpus linguistics research (Biber, 1988), and the third and final section of the book carries that work forward with three studies exploring how register and text type influence several linguistic variables. The first, by Yoon and Casal, looks at the way phrase frames are used for rhetorical purposes in applied linguistics conference abstracts, providing valuable insight into the importance of formulaic language in accomplishing communicative goals. Wright's chapter uses multi-dimensional analysis to

investigate another less-studied genre. The study seeks to describe distinguishing linguistic features of stand-alone literature reviews across disciplinary differences and time period, with significant variation found for both. The volume's final chapter, by Zuppari and Sardinha, focuses on the often-studied registers of research articles and academic textbooks, but takes an innovative methodological approach. Adapting Biber's (1988) multi-dimensional approach to collocation rather than the traditional features explored with this methodology, the authors describe dimensions of collocation while comparing the two registers.

With so much research happening across the extensive and varied field of corpus linguistics, keeping up with new developments requires wide reading. Compiled collections of thematically-organized work such as this provide a welcome starting point for investigating current research, and this volume suggests numerous paths for further development in the field. The primary strength of the collection is the range of methodologies used by the studies and the diverse contexts and sub-registers of academic writing they explore. Particularly valuable is the illustration of how quantitative methods of corpus linguistics can complement qualitative analysis to offer new insights into academic writing, like Gray, Cotos, and Smith's use of multi-dimensional analysis along with rhetorical move-step analysis. Another innovative methodology is presented by Zuppari and Sardinha with their look at dimensions of collocation. The chapters also present work on some less commonly explored areas in the field, including Studio Arts and Interior Design. Finally, though not the primary focus of the collection, many of the included studies provide pedagogical suggestions, which though likely not suitable for direct use by practitioners, do illustrate how corpus linguistics may offer guidance for academic writing practices

While this book offers a useful system of organization with its three subsections, the many topics and methodological approaches presented within them do not always feel cohesive thematically. It is unclear whether the variety of studies collected here are a reflection of general trends in current research, or whether another approach was taken in selecting studies to include. However, to be fair this is not being presented as an overview of the field of corpus linguistics, but instead aims to show new ways that researchers are using corpus methodology to add to our collective understanding of academic writing. Additionally, while this volume provides admirable diversity in the research it highlights, a considerable amount of background knowledge in several types of corpus analysis, as well as rhetorical move-step analysis, would be necessary to fully understand all of the work being presented. The addition of some basic orientation, possibly including brief introductions for each of the book's three major sections, may help novice researchers make best use of the information in this volume and contextualize the studies in the broader context of the literature, especially in regards to detailed methodological practices. Overall, despite some minor limitations, this book remains an excellent resource for corpus linguistics looking to stay abreast of innovative research in the field, and perhaps also for linguistic researchers outside of the corpus world looking to learn more about the ways this kind of research is being applied.

References

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